Lesson 19: Qualitative Research

English Stage 4 (Psychology) · Unit 3: Research Designs

Adapted from Research Methods in Psychology (4th American edition) by Rajiv S. Jhangiani, I-Chant A. Chiang, Carrie Cuttler and Dana C. Leighton (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 6.5: Qualitative Research.

In this lesson

Most psychology research is quantitative, but qualitative research is an important alternative: broad questions, rich data from a few people, and nonstatistical analysis. You will learn how qualitative researchers collect and analyze data (interviews, focus groups, grounded theory) and how the two approaches can be combined. In English, you will practice the language of contrast and the hedges researchers use when they say what a study "suggests."

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Compare qualitative and quantitative research in terms of questions, data, samples and analysis.
- Describe the three stages of grounded theory, using the book's study of postpartum depression.
- Explain two ways of combining the approaches: hypothesis generation and triangulation.
- Use contrast language (*while*, *whereas*) and hedges (*may*, *seems*, *suggests*) accurately.
- Plan a qualitative alternative to your study of sleep and memory.

Key language

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
quantitative research	focused questions, small amounts of data from many participants, descriptive and inferential statistics	most studies in psychology
qualitative research	broad questions, large amounts of data from a small number of participants, nonstatistical techniques	interviews with the families of 10 suicide victims
unstructured / semi-structured interview	a few general prompts that let participants talk about what interests them / a few consistent questions plus follow-up questions	"Can you tell me more about that?"
focus group	a small group of people interviewed together on a particular topic or issue	consumer research in business
grounded theory	analysis that starts with the data and develops a theory "grounded in" them (Glaser & Strauss, 1967)	Abrams and Curran (2009)

Term or phrase	Meaning	Example
theoretical narrative	in grounded theory, an interpretation of the broad themes in the data, supported by many direct quotations	depression tied to raising children alone
thick description	rich, detailed description of behavior in its real-world context (Geertz, 1973)	families' reactions, recorded in their homes
lived experience	what it is actually like to be in a particular group or situation	families showing the victim's bedroom
mixed-methods research	research that combines quantitative and qualitative approaches	a survey, then interviews
triangulation	in mixed-methods research, using quantitative and qualitative methods on the same topic, aiming at a single interpretation	Trenor et al. (2008)
on the grounds that	because (gives the reason for a criticism)	"...criticize qualitative methods on the grounds that they lack objectivity"
suggests that there may be	a cautious (hedged) conclusion	"...suggests that there may be a general relationship..."
it is unclear whether	the evidence cannot decide	"it is unclear whether this question would have arisen at all"

Rules and explanations

The ideas

Two approaches. Qualitative research began in anthropology and sociology.

	Quantitative	Qualitative
Question	specific and focused	broad, "global and exploratory"
Data	a little numerical data from many people	much relatively "unfiltered" data from a few people
Analysis	statistics	nonstatistical (e.g., grounded theory, thematic analysis)
Conclusions	general, about a large population	interpretations of participants' *experience*

An example. Lindqvist, Johansson and Karlsson (2008) did not ask a narrow question such as "What percentage of family members join suicide support groups?" They interviewed the families of 10 teenage suicide victims at home in rural Sweden to understand their reactions from *their* perspective. A key theme: even as life returned to "normal," families kept struggling with *why*, especially when the suicide was most unexpected.

Strengths. Quantitative research gives precise answers and general conclusions (for example, that people strongly tend to obey authority figures). Its weaknesses are the strengths of qualitative research:

1. generating new questions and hypotheses (Lindqvist's study suggests a link between how unexpected a suicide is and how consumed the family is with "why");
2. "thick description" of behavior in real-world contexts;
3. conveying "lived experience" (all the families offered to show the victim's bedroom or the place of the suicide).

Collecting data. Observation, archival data and even artwork are used, but interviews are most common: *unstructured* (Lindqvist's team chose this because the families, not the researchers, should decide how much to disclose on such a sensitive topic), *semi-structured* (most interviews) or *structured* (a strict script). In *focus groups*, interaction can bring out more information, but the wish to be liked can produce inaccurate answers, and extraverted participants can dominate.

Analysis: the clearest difference. If researchers interview people recovering from alcohol use disorder about their faith, then count mentions of God and use statistics to relate them to abstaining, the study becomes quantitative. What researchers *do with* the data matters more than how they collect them.

Grounded theory (Glaser & Strauss, 1967) reverses the quantitative order (theory, hypothesis, data). Researchers start with the data and:

1. identify ideas repeated throughout the data;
2. organize them into fewer, broader themes;
3. write a theoretical narrative focused on participants' subjective experience, supported by direct quotations.

Abrams and Curran (2009) interviewed 19 low-income mothers with postpartum depression symptoms (unstructured interviews) and found five themes: ambivalence, caregiving overload, juggling, mothering alone and real-life worry. Their narrative tied the symptoms not to an abstract "affective disorder" but to the daily struggle of raising children alone.

The "debate" and mixed methods. Some quantitative researchers say qualitative methods lack objectivity and generalizability; some qualitative researchers say quantitative methods overlook the richness of human experience. In fact, qualitative researchers have frameworks for these issues, and quantitative researchers simplify deliberately, as a strategy. Many now favor **mixed-methods research**:

- qualitative research generates a hypothesis; quantitative research tests it in a large sample;
- *triangulation*: both methods study the same question at the same time. Converging results reinforce each other; diverging results raise a new question.

Trenor et al. (2008): a survey of female engineering students showed no ethnic differences in sense of belonging, but in interviews many minority students said that the university's cultural diversity *enhanced* their belonging. The survey alone could have led to the wrong conclusion.

Language focus

1. Comparing and contrasting.

- *while* + clause, main clause: "But while quantitative research is good at providing precise answers to specific research questions, it is not nearly as good at *generating* novel and interesting research questions."
- *although …, it is X that …* (contrast plus emphasis): "Although quantitative and qualitative research generally differ along several important dimensions …, it is the method of data analysis that distinguishes them more clearly than anything else."
- *just as …, …* (similarity): "Just as there are many ways to collect data in qualitative research, there are many ways to analyze data."

2. Hedging interpretations. Qualitative findings are interpretations, so the authors hedge them: "This struggle *appeared to be* especially difficult …"; "*It seems unlikely that* a quantitative study would have discovered this detail." An established finding has no hedge and uses the present tense: "This method is how we know that people have a strong tendency to obey authority figures."

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic often links ideas with *wa* ("and"). In English academic writing, mark a contrast explicitly with *while*, *whereas*, *however* or *in contrast*. - *On the other hand* introduces a contrast, not an extra point; to add a point, use *moreover* or *in addition*.

Practice

1. Reading questions

- 1.1 What four things do quantitative researchers typically do (first paragraph)?
- 1.2 Why did Lindqvist and colleagues use unstructured interviews?
- 1.3 Give two ways in which group dynamics can affect focus-group data.
- 1.4 In the alcohol use disorder example, what makes the study quantitative, and what general point does it make?
- 1.5 How does the order of steps in grounded theory differ from the usual quantitative order?
- 1.6 How many mothers did Abrams and Curran interview, and with what kind of interview?
- 1.7 Did the studies by Lindqvist and colleagues and by Abrams and Curran use only qualitative methods?
- 1.8 In triangulation, what do converging and diverging results mean?

2. Applying the section (Section 6.5 has no exercises; the chapter's exercises are in Lesson 20.)

- 2.1 Without looking at the table in the section, sort these repeating ideas from Abrams and Curran (2009) into the five themes: (a) "Everyone depends on me" (b) "I need a break" (c) "My baby has no father" (d) "I wasn't prepared for this baby" (e) "It's not safe here" (f) "Navigating the maze" (g) "Please stop crying" (h) "I don't have any money".
- 2.2 Planning task: the section says that the relationship suggested by Lindqvist's study "can now be explored using quantitative research." Outline such a study: variables and measures, sample,

analysis, and one ethical precaution.

3. Language

- 3.1 Join each pair into one sentence with *while* or *whereas*. (a) Quantitative research bases its conclusions on statistical analyses. Qualitative research bases its conclusions on the investigator's interpretations. (b) Unstructured interviews use a few general prompts. Structured interviews follow a strict script.
- 3.2 Find the hedge in each sentence. Then rewrite (b) without it and say why the result would be inaccurate. (a) "Some quantitative researchers criticize qualitative methods on the grounds that they lack objectivity." (b) "Highly extraverted participants can sometimes dominate discussions within focus groups." (c) "Without the qualitative component, we might have drawn the wrong conclusion about the quantitative results."

Speak with your tutor

- Explain the difference between qualitative and quantitative research with the Lindqvist study as your example. Ask the tutor to correct your contrast language.
- Ask the tutor to play a researcher who says qualitative research "lacks objectivity." Reply with points from the section (frameworks, hypothesis generation, triangulation, the Trenor study).
- Ask the tutor to play a student who sleeps badly. Conduct a short semi-structured interview: three consistent questions plus follow-up questions. Then list the repeating ideas and group them into themes.
- In PSYC 110 Lecture 20 (The Good Life: Happiness), Professor Bloom describes research that asks people "How happy are you?" on a scale of one to ten. Discuss what a qualitative study of happiness could add to these numbers and what it would lose.

Writing task

Research project: a qualitative alternative (180-250 words). Describe a qualitative alternative to your quantitative study of sleep and memory in university students; it could also be the first stage of a mixed-methods project. Include:

1. a broad research question (for example, how students experience the link between their sleep and remembering what they study);
2. participants: who, how many, and why a small sample is acceptable;
3. data collection: interview type (or focus groups) and why, with two or three example questions;
4. analysis: the three stages of grounded theory (Glaser & Strauss, 1967);
5. how it would combine with your quantitative design (hypothesis generation or triangulation);
6. one limitation and one ethical point (for example, confidential recordings).

Use *will* for the procedure, one *while/whereas* sentence comparing this plan with your quantitative design, and hedges for possible findings. If you work on your own topic, write the same six parts for it.

Self-editing checklist

- Is the question broad and open (not yes/no or "what percentage")?
- Did you name and justify the interview type?
- Are the grounded-theory stages in the right order?
- Is there a correct contrast sentence?
- Are possible findings hedged and procedures in *will*?
- Are technical terms defined on first use?
- Is the citation in APA style?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- The full study by Lindqvist et al. (2008), linked in Section 6.5 (free full text in PubMed Central): https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2375873/

Answer key

1. Reading questions

- 1.1 Start with a focused question or hypothesis; collect a small amount of numerical data from many individuals; describe it statistically; draw general conclusions about a large population ("What Is Qualitative Research?").
- 1.2 Because, on such a sensitive topic, how much was disclosed should be led by the families, not the researchers ("Data Collection and Analysis").
- 1.3 The desire to be liked can lead to inaccurate answers that participants think others will view favorably; highly extraverted participants can dominate.
- 1.4 Coding how often each participant mentions God and using descriptive and inferential statistics to relate this to abstaining. The distinction depends more on what researchers do with the data than on why or how they collected them.
- 1.5 Quantitative: theory, then a hypothesis, then data to test it. Grounded theory: data first, then a theory developed from ("grounded in") the data.
- 1.6 19 mothers; unstructured interviews.
- 1.7 No: both combined quantitative and qualitative approaches ("The Quantitative-Qualitative 'Debate'").
- 1.8 Converging results reinforce and enrich each other; diverging results suggest a new question: why do they diverge, and how can they be reconciled?

2. Applying the section

- 2.1 Ambivalence: (d). Caregiving overload: (b), (g). Juggling: (a), (f). Mothering alone: (c). Real-life worry: (e), (h).
- 2.2 (example answer) Hypothesis: the more unexpected the suicide, the more family members struggle with why it happened. Measure unexpectedness on a rating scale (1 = completely expected, 7 = completely unexpected) and the struggle with a short questionnaire. Recruit a large sample of bereaved family members, for example through support services, and compute Pearson's *r*. A positive correlation would support the hypothesis but could not show causation. Ethics: informed consent, the right to withdraw, confidentiality and information about support, because the topic is very sensitive. Other designs are possible.

3. Language

- 3.1 (example answers; *while* and *whereas* are interchangeable here) (a) Quantitative research bases its conclusions on statistical analyses, whereas qualitative research bases its conclusions on the investigator's interpretations. (b) While unstructured interviews use a few general prompts, structured interviews follow a strict script.
- 3.2 (a) *Some* (b) *can sometimes* (c) *might*. Unhedged (b): "Highly extraverted participants dominate discussions within focus groups." This claims that it always happens; the section presents it only as a possibility.

My notes